CHAPTER 2 Becoming the Hindi Heartland's Predominant Rural Party

1. In multipolar election contests in the first-past-the-post system, the effective number of political parties/players increases. Bipolarity represents a two-way concentration of votes. The minimal level of a multipolar configuration would be a three-way contest. In states like UP, it could be even higher. While there are often a large number of parties contesting a particular seat, there are various ways to statistically compute the 'effective' number of political parties (i.e., the number of key contenders) in the contest. One of the most common techniques is to use the inverse of the square root of the sum of the squares of their vote share. The formula is as below: Effective Number of Political Parties = 1/SQRT((A)^2+(B)^2+(C)^2). As per this, if we are to assume that UP has at a minimum number of three parties in contest, the formula is written as 3 = 1/SQRT((A)^2+(B)^2+(C)^2).

   Repeated iterations of this formula show that the value of the LHS remains around three (the conservative case we are trying to establish in the case of UP, if at least one of the variables of A, B and C remain above 0.4, which is 40 per cent. At its point of inflexion, it assumes that even if two of the three parties obtain 30 per cent each, one of them still needs to touch the 40 per cent mark to obtain an effective number of political parties as three. With the vote share of one party at larger than 40 per cent, the number starts dropping below three and the contest starts getting closer to a bipolar scenario marking a definitive departure from a purely triangular contest and signifying the dominance of one party among the three. We, therefore, set 40 per cent as a premium performance benchmark for saying that a party has indeed made a decisive presence in three-way (or more) contests. I am grateful to Jai Mrug for this calculation and explanation.
2. Interview with Keshav Prasad Maurya, deputy chief minister, UP; former president, UP BJP; former BJP MP from Phulpur, 8 June 2020, Lucknow.